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EUPSYCHIA—THE GOOD SOCIETY¹

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Mr. Thomas: "Dr. Maslow, during the next few minutes we are going to be talking about good societies and about your ideas on the psychological foundations of good societies. I remarked as we were coming into the studio that these were rather peculiar times to be discussing Utopias. Utopian societies have traditionally been descriptions of economic achievement—a place where the material needs of food, clothing, shelter, were completely filled. Why, then, in America where we have apparently solved these material problems, do we still feel compelled to reach out, to define better societies? Why are we dissatisfied? Why do we go on imagining Utopias?"

Dr. Maslow: "I think we're simply witnessing a human phenomenon that has appeared down through the ages. What man does not have, he struggles for. When the need is fulfilled, he moves to a different and higher need. The picture of the ideal society reflects the level of poverty or wealth of the current culture and, incidentally, of the individual's own concept of how rich he is, and how rich he wants to become. The fact that America is very rich—that all the things for which most cultures have struggled throughout history have been achieved here—is tending to push our thoughts to higher needs and therefore to higher levels of frustration."

Mr. Thomas: "Would you say something about the difference between 'higher' and 'lower' needs?"

Dr. Maslow: "Well, I think most psychologists now agree that our needs are arranged in a kind of hierarchy, with food and shelter the lowest on the scale. When our bellies are full and we are sheltered, we turn towards the problems of safety and security in the world. We want a good police force and good doctors. Then, we think of education, and we want good schools. This reminds me of that old cartoon where the wife says to the husband 'You are always wanting what you haven't got,' and he answers, 'Well, what else can you want?'"

"Now, I think of love as a higher need, and beyond love there are the still higher needs for respect from others, for self respect, and so on. You can see that the higher the need, the less it is directly related to the basic material and physical needs. For these reasons I think it is entirely valid to be imagining better societies in America at this point in our history; but, I think we are now

¹ Based on an interview by Trevor Thomas of the Pacifica Foundation, over radio station KPFA-FM, August 1960. Edited by Robert Greenway.

ready to conceive of a 'Eupsychia'—a psychologically healthy culture—rather than just another materially-based Utopia."

Mr. Thomas: "It seems to me that many people stay at the material level, building up stronger and stronger motives to gain more and more material possessions, even though they are aware, at least vaguely, of these higher needs. How does one become so aware of these higher needs that there are motives to act on them?"

Dr. Maslow: "This is a problem of ignorance or of pathology. We psychologists must conclude—on the basis of extensive clinical studies—that the person who continues to build up wealth after his needs are satisfied is actually looking for something else. The possessions perhaps symbolize the power or the respect he is seeking; or he may feel unconsciously that wealth will make him a more lovable or attractive person. We would simply call this neurotic, or, possibly ignorant."

"A good example of this is the history of what trade unions have struggled for over the years. In the old days, perhaps sixty years ago, a union struck for food. Now that union laborers have more money, more food, and many other benefits, what are they striking for? If you dig below the surface, as some labor union economists are doing, it appears that unions are following the hierarchy of needs that I have been talking about. First they struck for food, then for security; now I think we could say that unions are striking for self respect—for a feeling of being masters over their own fate, for power rather than powerlessness."

Mr. Thomas: "What about these two words, 'power' and 'powerlessness'? Certain social critics—Erich Fromm comes to mind—have been very much concerned about the isolation of the individual and his feeling of powerlessness. What do you mean when you talk about the need to feel power?"

Dr. Maslow: "Again, I would define power as the feeling of self-respect, especially in males. Or, you could say the feeling of having some control over fate, of not being a helpless tool, a passive object, a cork on the wave which is tossed here and there by forces out of control. This characterizes power as a very healthy, straightforward trait, a very desirable thing for any human being."

"Then of course psychologists can talk of power in a pathological sense as something for which people *think* they are looking, but which is actually a symbol for something else."

Mr. Thomas: "You've made a distinction between 'good love' and 'good power', and between 'pathological love' and 'pathological power.' This leads me to ask what you as a psychologist know about the 'good side' of people. I've heard and read a good deal about the 'evil side', what do we know about the 'good side'?"

Dr. Maslow: "From a strict scientific point of view, using classical traditions of scientific exploration, we "know" very, very little. However, there are pilot studies of one sort or another in this area and I feel we are gaining a level of knowledge that will allow some

generalizations. Actually, we have a huge mass of clinical knowledge—we shouldn't overlook the fact that most psychotherapeutic cases go from 'bad to 'better'—from 'less healthy' to 'more healthy'.

"My own research was simply to pick out the healthiest people I could find, and then to study them directly. It was a small sampling, for there certainly aren't very many truly healthy individuals in this society. I just tried to find out what they were like. How did they feel? What kind of humor, interpersonal relations, families, demeanors did they have? What were their relationships to society? These were the kind of questions I asked, and I found to my satisfaction that it was possible to make some important preliminary generalizations from their answers—generalizations which on the whole have stood up remarkably well in the light of my own additional findings since then, and of those of many other psychologists which have accumulated during the fifteen years since this survey was first carried out."

Mr. Thomas: "And what were some of these generalizations?"

Dr. Maslow: "Well, for instance, just to pick out the most important ones, it was very clear in my pilot study that either the most important or one of the most important characteristics of psychological health was simply the ability to perceive clearly—that is, to see the truth, to penetrate falsehood, phoniness, hypocrisy, and so on. This was very clear and has been supported a dozen times over by other people, by the results of psychotherapy, which is after all, an effort to make a good man, too. This is pretty clear now; I think it is safe to say that psychologically healthy people are just more perceptive, they can see the truth more clearly, they are less fooled by masks, conventions, and expectations. They can penetrate through to the truth more easily, more clearly."

Mr. Thomas: "I guess this leads to the next obvious question, then: What is the factor in psychologically healthy people that permits them to be more capable of this perception?"

Dr. Maslow: "We don't have the time to talk about it at length, but for our purposes here we can call it a unique lack of fear. It is fear that puts blinders on our eyes and that puts shackles on us. You could also call it anxiety, inhibition, or lack of confidence. Whatever the term, it is the main psychological block to a Eupsychia—a society of psychologically healthy people."

"I might then go on and describe the second most important characteristic of healthy people—and the second basic foundation of Eupsychia—as spontaneity, or the capacity to function fully, to live with a certain naturalness, simplicity, lack of artificiality or guile."

Mr. Thomas: "Dr. Maslow, this word 'spontaneity' is quite common in much current popular literature. I would see the word as being tied in with the concept of creativity. Would you see it this way?"

Dr. Maslow: "Very definitely."

Mr. Thomas: "Would you sort of nip the two concepts together for us?"

Dr. Maslow: "Being creative is being spontaneous—and it takes courage. Certainly one aspect of the creative person is that he must be strong, or let us say, unafraid. The creative person sticks his neck out when he has an idea. He may be defying the whole culture, even the whole of history. He is saying that what everyone accepts as the whole truth just isn't good enough. He is evidencing a certain defiance and perhaps a certain loneliness. To maintain this spontaneity—and thus, creativeness, he must overcome the fear of being in this very vulnerable position. Since we are all creative to some extent, perhaps those of our culture who evidence creativeness are simply those people with the ability to overcome a fear of spontaneity."

Mr. Thomas: "The fear is always present then, but the successful person is able to overcome it and 'be spontaneous' and thus 'creative'?"

Dr. Maslow: "Yes. When he overcomes his fear he can then permit what is inside of him to emerge—even if other people laugh at him, even if he looks ridiculous, even if his emerging idea is a mistake, as so many creations are, and he has to throw it away and be laughed at even more for this. He must be strong to withstand this.

"Now in our Eupsychia, where everyone by definition would be psychologically healthy, everyone would be able to handle spontaneous ideas, and because there would be fewer personal hostilities there would be very little fear—and thus great spontaneity and creativity. People would trust themselves; they would look forward to new ideas, to novelty, to change. There would be no need to hang on to the past—people would happily adapt to changing conditions.

Mr. Thomas: "This certainly runs counter to the 'utility' or 'usefulness' concept commonly held in our culture—the idea that the end product is the important thing, not the means or the 'doing.' We tend to regard education as a tool. We are always concerned about the use to which it will be put, about how much added income will result from it. I gather, from what you are saying that the end product of the creative process may not be the most important part of it. Aren't you somewhat in conflict with these traditionally held values?"

Dr. Maslow: "Well, I think the old notions of 'usefulness' are breaking up a little, not only because academic people and intellectuals object to it, but because the government and many industries are finding out the hard way that there is no system, no easy way, no method for generating really new, creative ideas. Industry is embarked on a five billion dollar annual quest for research results. They are finding that emphasis on use literally kills off creativity. They are learning to relax a little and wait for the really new, useful product. It is kind of a package deal—the great creative break-throughs come when the people who play with ideas are perfectly willing to make lots of ludicrous mistakes. It is from the people who can toss these mistakes aside and go on, who dare to

think in a crazy, unusual way—it is from these people that really new, useful ideas and things come, and often as a by-product. Incidentally, it is the same way with happiness; it usually comes as a by-product—you don't 'get happy' by looking for it directly."

Mr. Thomas: "It seems to me that this 'non-utility' concept might also run counter to an image many of us carry about psychologists who do 'adjustment' work in industry, in schools, and as family advisors. What is your reaction to the adjustment concept of psychology?"

Dr. Maslow: "I would say that in the last ten years, most if not all, leading theorists in psychology have become anti-adjustment."

Mr. Thomas: "There are, of course, many 'adjustment' practitioners, are there not?"

Dr. Maslow: "Well, this is another story. The theorist can live in his own ideal world. He conceives the ideal, and to him adjusting means adjusting to an ideal culture. But we know the culture is not perfect. We have learned to ask whether we are going to advocate adjusting to the dope addicts down the block, the Nazis around the corner, or the Negro haters in the next city. **To be adjusted to stinkers is to be a stinker yourself.** A requisite of Eupsychia is that adjustment is a neutral concept. To adjust to good would be good; to adjust to bad would be bad. Theoretically, the problem wouldn't come up in Eupsychia.

"Instead of cultural relativity, I am implying that there are basic, underlying, human standards that are cross-cultural—which transcend cultures and which are broadly human. Without these standards we simply would have no criterion for criticizing, let us say, the well-adjusted Nazi in Nazi Germany."

Mr. Thomas: "You would say that without certain standards, you couldn't criticize the Nazi because his adjustment would be simply a reflection of the culture in which he finds himself?"

Dr. Maslow: "Yes, we need principles which stand above cultures and which can help us evaluate any culture, any human behaviour. Then we can criticize the Nazi for just being adjusted—for not fighting a bad culture. As I mentioned a few minutes ago, we're looking for these principles in the healthiest people we could find."

Mr. Thomas: "Aren't these principles the same basic values that every religion and philosophy has attempted to find—a quest as old as cultures themselves? How does your approach as a psychologist differ from the philosopher or theologian?"

Dr. Maslow: "I think my approach differs tremendously and the difference can be stated very, very simply. It is certainly true that mankind, throughout history, has looked for guiding values, for principles of right and wrong. But he has tended to look outside of himself, outside of mankind, to a God, to some sort of sacred book perhaps, or to a ruling class. **What I am doing is to explore the theory that you can find the values by which mankind must live, and for which man has always sought, by digging into the best people in depth.** I believe, in other words, that I can find ultimate

values which are right for mankind by observing the best of mankind. If under the best conditions and in the best specimens I simply stand aside and describe in a scientific way what these human values are, I find values that are the old values of truth, goodness, and beauty and some additional ones as well, for instance, gaiety, justice and joy. I do not say we should look for goodness because we ought to, or because there is some principle outside of ourselves that tells us to. I am saying that if you examine human beings fairly, you will find that they themselves have innate knowledge of and yearning for, goodness and beauty. Now there is an important reason why we don't see more of these good instincts; we are afraid of them, we tend to block their expression—the fear that I was mentioning earlier—even though we have a deep yearning for their expression. Our task is to create an environment where more and more of these innate instincts can find expression. This is what would characterize Eupsychia."

Mr. Thomas: "You would say then that this theory refutes the concept of the completely malleable personality—the so-called blank slate?"

Dr. Maslow: "Oh yes. Most psychological theorists have given that up. Some version of biological theory, or instinct theory, or basic need theory, or whatever you want to call it, is absolutely necessary for such a conception as I've outlined. Furthermore, I am saying that these basic needs are good, and that careful study of them will provide the values we need by which better societies can evolve."

Mr. Thomas: "Even such broad complex concepts as justice? Is this a constituent of all people and all cultures, in the same way that your concept of goodness is a cultural universal?"

Dr. Maslow: "Yes, I would say that every known culture has some kind of concept of justice."

Mr. Thomas: "What are some other universal constants of cultures?"

Dr. Maslow: "Another example is responsibility to certain other human beings. Every culture limits whom you can kill, to whom you can be hostile or kind, the persons to whom you have duties and obligations. Of course this is a cross-cultural generalization, but I would say that every culture has some kind of cosmology—call it religion if you prefer—some picture of the world and man's proper relationship to it; in other words, a philosophy, good or bad, true or false."

Mr. Thomas: "You mean that despite 'good' cosmologies, philosophies, religions, value systems, a culture can still be 'bad'?"

Dr. Maslow: "Yes, we certainly know that throughout history cultures have attempted to exterminate one another, to maintain and advance their particular brand of cosmology. The good impulses within people are easily warped by cultures—you never find them in their pure state. The people within a culture may, deep within themselves, hold the universal constant of justice. Within the framework of a bad culture it can be twisted into an instrument of evil."

Mr. Thomas: "It would follow, then, that your Eupsychia—the

ideal community of healthy people—would have an emphasis opposite from most Utopian ideals. A Utopia has usually been a good community, a good system, which produced the good life. You are saying that in Eupsychia, good lives will produce the good culture."

Dr. Maslow: "Well, let me say that creating an imaginary culture, a Eupsychia, is a game that I enjoy playing. At the same time it is a game from which very serious consequences can flow; **all the more if I can remain spontaneous about the concept and let the fantasies roam free.** On the other hand, I certainly must remain realistic and ask myself why so few people press for truth, beauty, and goodness, when these impulses are in all of us. Though we have a tendency, a yearning for these basic values, what keeps them from us? Are they strong enough to produce Eupsychia?"

"I just said above that these impulses—these innate values—can be easily warped by a culture. But there is also another reason that they seem to appear infrequently; we tend to fear them. This fear—and rejection—of values is now occupying me theoretically; it has already occupied many psychologists for a long time under the general heading of psychopathology. For myself, I call this 'counter-morality'. We know a great deal about why man, when given a choice, chooses evil over good—why he fears ultimate values—from the studies of psychopathology."

Mr. Thomas: "Would you expand on that—on 'fear of ultimate values'?"

Dr. Maslow: "Well, one example I can speak of is that we are really *afraid* to be nice, to be decent and tender. One psychologist wrote a chapter on this entitled 'The Taboo on Tenderness.' We are afraid to be boy scouts, to be soft—especially the men in our culture. One reason for this—one which impresses me very much and has changed my thinking and seems to be a very valuable tool—is that these ultimate values, or instinct-like needs (or call them biologically-based left-overs from our animal heritage); these are *not* strong, *not* overpowering as everybody has always thought but rather they are very weak, subtle, delicate. **They can be easily overcome by a culture gone bad; for example,** a culture that has built up an over-tough conception of masculinity which suppresses impulses such as love, kindness, and tenderness. These instincts are easily overcome by learning, habit, tradition. **Part of the job of Eupsychia would be, not to protect itself from instincts, as Freud would have it; but rather to make society into an environment which would encourage instinct strengthening and would call out and use these valuable elements** which are so feared, so delicate, so easily overcome and so mistrusted."

Mr. Thomas: "Now you're talking about the instincts for good, not the evil instincts?"

Dr. Maslow: "As far as I know we just don't have any **intrinsic instincts for evil.** If you think in terms of the basic needs; instincts, at least at the outset, are all 'good'—or perhaps we should be

technical about it and call them 'pre-moral,' neither good nor evil. We do know, however, that out of the search for fulfillment of a basic need—take love in the child for example—can come evil. The child, wanting his mother's exclusive love, may bash his little brother over the head in hopes of getting more of it. What we call evil or pathological may certainly arise from, or replace, something good. Another example is the little squabbles among children; all the fighting they do about who should do what, about dividing up the chores, ultimately can be seen as a distorted expression of a very powerful need for fairness and justice."

Mr. Thomas: "It seems to me that Eupsychia would be a good place for the nurture of these good instincts. But the question I have is, that if these instincts are so weak and easily damaged, how can we bring them out before we have Eupsychia? How, in our present cultures, can we work toward the healthy society?"

Dr. Maslow: "The primary technical tool we now have for doing this, and I suppose the best way for doing it, is by psychoanalysis or by some other form of depth analysis with the help of a skilled person. However, since this is not a very practical suggestion for most of us, certainly not for most of mankind, we must turn our attention more and more to mass techniques of helping the person to discover this precious human nature deep within himself—this nature that he is afraid of expressing. Education, for example, certainly should help the person discover his own human nature, as should self-therapy. Self-therapy is applicable to all of us, although it is an extremely difficult job; we have only a few guide lines, a few models. One good guide, one which I frequently recommend to my students, is a paperback by Joanna Field called *A Life of One's Own*. It is a model for self-search and a description of a technique for doing it. Another good help is a book by the same author but under her own name, Marion Milner, *On Not Being Able to Paint*.

"In general, the consequences of psychotherapy are moves toward better values. The person in successful therapy generally comes out a better citizen, a better husband, a better wife—certainly a better person. He is more perceptive and more spontaneous—this practically always happens. These results are achieved through self-knowledge—the main path to discovering within ourselves the best values for all mankind. The more clearly we know these values, the more easily, spontaneously, effortlessly we can grope toward them.

"Let me put it in an old-fashioned way. One of the results of good psychotherapy is to be better able to decide between bad and good, and between the beautiful and the ugly. It's like learning to have better taste; and this, again, is via self-knowledge. You can also put it the other way around; if you think of all these therapies as simply uncovering something which is there beforehand—and that is what good therapy is supposed to do—what is uncovered is what we in our culture today call good values."

Mr. Thomas: "Doesn't it follow from this, Dr. Maslow, that the person undergoing therapy in his search for a good life must some-

how reconcile all the external pressures with this image of the good as it develops? And isn't this becoming more and more difficult in our culture?"

Dr. Maslow: "While it is certainly true that cultures can block innate impulses which are good, I hope I won't sound Pollyanna if I say that the cultural pressures are really not as pressing as people sometimes make them out to be, at least in America. It is very frequently possible, especially for the young person who doesn't yet have many commitments, to simply get off the merry-go-round—to say 'nuts' to cultural pressures. In our open society this is possible; you can just about pick your way of life, you can choose something which won't trap you. It is, of course, a different story for the middle-aged man or woman. They are already committed to so many things that about the only thing that therapy can do for them is to give them strength to bear with fortitude what they have to bear.

"I would say that most psychologists regard this talk about cultural pressures as a kind of alibi. It's like saying 'poor me, I'm so helpless, I must do what I'm told.' But this is phony, especially when you're young; you don't really have to do what you're told. Does this sound too extreme to you?"

Mr. Thomas: "No, it doesn't, but I'm curious about how many of the young people you know through your work at Brandeis University would be willing to kick that part of the culture which was blocking them—let's say, preventing healthy growth. How many would say 'nuts' to the culture?"

Dr. Maslow: "Well, it is true that young people are more afraid than healthy older people these days. They have to be helped by having alternatives set before them. They then become involved in debates over the classical thinkers; they compare this bill of goods, this way of life with that way of life, and then they have to choose. Sometimes the culture is not the unanimous choice.

"I would guess, to answer your question, that about one-third or one-fourth of our students are what you'd call struggling, groping, earnest, self-making, self-creating individuals. These are the students that will retain all the possibilities of growth and development throughout the rest of their adult lives."

Mr. Thomas: "I would say that this is an impressive number."

Dr. Maslow: "Yes, it is a large proportion from one point of view. And of course Brandeis students are very bright, very carefully selected. From another point of view, however, you can certainly feel sad about the majority, the students who will walk through their studies. They may do well—get good grades, do what they are supposed to do. They learn, but in a passive way, without really deciding on a life path. They just play along with what is laid out for them. You might say they accept the dominating elements of the culture—both the good and the bad—without choosing, without questioning too much. Of course, in that sense they become educated, but not all educated people are wise—not all educated

people keep on growing. As someone said, 'Any dope can have a high I.Q.'"

Mr. Thomas: "What would be the major function of education in Eupsychia? Or better yet, why not just tell us more about Eupsychia?"

Dr. Maslow: "The way you ask the question, it sounds as if it exists! It occurs to me now that perhaps it really does in one sense. I'll mention this in a moment. As I said earlier, the way I started playing the game was after studying self-actualizing people and learning how they behaved with each other, interpersonally, and with their families, their children. I observed that their relationships with other people showed certain differences from the average. I groped toward these differences, tried to formulate them, tried to get them clearer in my own mind. It was from this search that I began to wonder what the world would be like if all people had developed to the level of maturity and wisdom of these healthy people. Or, what kind of a culture would be generated by a thousand of these mature individuals if they were placed on a desert island and not confronted with outside cultural forces. What kind of values would they have?"

"My answers—tentative of course, but nevertheless very provocative—grew from my studies of psychologically healthy people. It appears that there would be a very great respect for individual differences—more permissiveness for other people to grow in their own style. In this sense it would certainly be a democratic culture. The trend might even be toward what the philosophical anarchists used to talk about. Certainly there would be less crime, less impulse toward it, less need for it. There would perhaps be no laws or constitutions, except those written to protect the society against the insanities, the feeble-mindedness, the illnesses which can produce evil; brain fever, for example, which produces uncontrollable hostility, and so on. But these laws would be in the background. We certainly wouldn't need armies. Our isolated group of healthy individuals would certainly transcend nationalism, our great curse at present—the local patriotism which may kill us all yet. I know from studying these healthy individuals that they have less of the so-called 'national character'—that is, in a certain meaningful sense, they are international people."

Mr. Thomas: "Because they find less need to be 'national'?"

Dr. Maslow: "Yes, they feel brotherly towards all mankind—and especially toward their own kind of healthy person, whether he happens to be Japanese, German, American, or Russian. The truly healthy people all seem to be members of the same culture. It is in this sense that Eupsychia exists already. In the middle of the messy cultures that we have today there may be a thousand of these healthy individuals; the new Eupsychia. I'm sure they could get along with each other very, very nicely. I've seen it happen on a small scale."

Mr. Thomas: "Our time is about up, Dr. Maslow, and before we

close this very interesting discussion, let me ask you if you know of people in other disciplines—economists, political scientists, anthropologists—who share this idea. Is there a journal of communication?"

Dr. Maslow: "Yes, there is a good deal of correspondence between people in many different fields. One periodical published on the West Coast called *Manas* carries articles from many disciplines—psychological, sociological, philosophical, religious—all pressing toward an understanding of better men and better cultures. Then there is the new *American Association For Humanistic Psychology* which will soon be publishing a journal."²

² *Editor's note:* The first issue of the *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* appeared in April, 1961.

The *American Association for Humanistic Psychology* is now being organized—see Editor's Preface in *Journal of Humanistic Psychology*, Volume 1, Number 2.